zomato

ZOMATO · FOOD DELIVERY PLATFORM

# Improving Farm-to-Table Discovery of Restaurants

Product Case Study

PROBLEM STATEMENT

# Urban food consumers in India are increasingly health-conscious and values-driven, yet the Zomato ordering experience offers no mechanism to discover, verify, or prefer meals made with locally sourced ingredients.

At the same time, small-scale farmers and farm-to-table restaurants that invest in sustainable sourcing have no way to signal this differentiation within the platform — making their premium positioning invisible and economically unjustifiable to end consumers.

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**The result is a broken value chain: consumers order blind to ingredient origin, restaurants cannot monetise their sourcing story, and local farmers remain locked out of urban demand despite sitting geographically close to it.**

01

# Background and Context

Market trends · External factors · Current scenario · Limitations

# Market Trends

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| 68% | 10,000+ | 3–4 | 20–40% |
| of urban Indian consumers are willing to pay a premium for sustainably sourced food (Nielsen, 2023) | registered FPOs hold high-quality local produce with no efficient urban distribution channel — supply exists but is disconnected from demand | food delivery orders per week per urban Indian, making food-tech the highest-frequency lever to shift food consumption behaviour at scale | higher ASPs at farm-to-table restaurants in Mumbai, Bengaluru, Delhi, and Pune — yet their differentiation is entirely invisible on the platform |

- Post-COVID health consciousness has structurally shifted food priorities — immunity, ingredient quality, and gut health are now mainstream concerns, not niche ones
- The conscious consumer cohort — millennials and Gen Z — represents Zomato's highest-LTV users by order frequency and AOV

# External Factors

### Regulatory pressure

FSSAI's Eat Right India initiative is moving toward ingredient traceability mandates; building a voluntary sourcing layer now means compliance readiness later, not reactive scrambling

### Consumer behaviour shift

Post-pandemic India saw a sustained rise in food provenance interest; CSA subscriptions, farm-to-fork restaurant growth, and brands like Organic India entering mainstream households confirm the consumer has shifted ahead of the platform

### Climate and macro risk

Erratic monsoons, crop losses, and supply chain disruptions have made local sourcing a resilience argument for consumers

### Competitive pressure

Swiggy has a shallow self-declared "Healthy" filter; Deliveroo launched a "Sustainable Restaurants" badge in the UK; DoorDash has tested local-first discovery in the US — the first mover to build a verified, credible layer sets the trust standard others are measured against

### Infrastructure readiness

Cold chain improvements, GPS-enabled farm-to-warehouse tracking, and QR-based provenance labelling have significantly lowered the technical and cost barrier to building a sourcing layer compared to 2019

CURRENT SCENARIO

# How Consumers Solve It Today

## Users resort to high-effort, low-reliability workarounds outside the platform

01 **Google search before ordering** — looking up whether a specific restaurant sources locally or has farm-to-table credentials, adding significant friction to the decision

02 **Instagram and food blogs** — conscious consumers follow food influencers and farm-to-fork content creators to discover restaurants, then cross-reference on Zomato to order

03 **Word of mouth** — recommendations from friends or community groups (WhatsApp, Reddit, housing society groups) for trusted farm-fresh or organic restaurants

04 **Direct ordering from farm brands** — Country Delight, Two Brothers Organic Farms, and similar D2C brands are capturing demand that could otherwise flow through Zomato, because they offer provenance that Zomato cannot

05 **Restaurant websites and menus** — some farm-to-table restaurants publish sourcing information on their own websites; users visit these before placing orders on aggregators

CURRENT SCENARIO

# How Farmers and Producers Solve It Today

**Farmers have no direct consumer channel at all — they are entirely B2B**

### FPO aggregators

Ninjacart and Waycool connect farmers to restaurants and cloud kitchens in bulk, but the farmer remains invisible to the end consumer

### D2C subscription boxes

Two Brothers, Organic India, and Country Delight are the only model where farmers have direct consumer visibility — but this is a separate product category from restaurant ordering

### Government schemes

e-NAM (National Agriculture Market) focuses on wholesale price discovery, not consumer-facing branding

CURRENT SCENARIO

# Limitations of Available Solutions

### High discovery friction

Users lack a centralized, reliable source of truth for identifying farm-to-table restaurants, forcing them to rely on fragmented, often outdated information from multiple off-platform channels before making a decision.

### Low trust and verification

There is no credible mechanism to validate restaurant claims (e.g. "farm fresh"), and relevant quality signals are buried in unstructured reviews — making it difficult for users to distinguish authentic offerings from marketing noise.

### Discovery is not systematic

Current discovery is driven by incomplete and biased channels (influencers, media, word-of-mouth), resulting in inconsistent and non-exhaustive coverage of relevant restaurant options.

### Platform abandonment

Users frequently leave the platform to verify information externally, creating drop-offs in the conversion funnel and leading to loss of both transactions and valuable behavioural data.

### No reinforcement loop

The platform fails to learn from or persist user preferences (e.g. interest in farm-to-table dining), resulting in repeated effort for users and no cumulative improvement in personalisation over time.

02

# Goals, Personas, and Stories

Business and user objectives · Three personas · Prioritisation · User stories

GOAL

# Business Objectives

01 Make Zomato relevant to globally emerging consumer trends shaped by the idea of Sustainability.

02 **Grow the health-conscious user segment** — acquire new users who currently bypass Zomato in favour of D2C farm brands or direct restaurant ordering, by offering them a discovery utility they cannot find elsewhere

03 **Expand restaurant partner supply** — onboard farm-to-table and sustainably-sourced restaurants that are currently under-indexed on the platform or prefer dine-in over delivery due to lack of differentiation

STRATEGIC BUSINESS ADVANTAGE

Solving both simultaneously is what makes this a compelling platform play for Zomato — it creates a network effect where more farmer-linked restaurants attract more values-driven consumers, which in turn incentivises more restaurants to source locally.

GOAL

# User Objectives

### Discover with confidence

Users want to identify restaurants and dishes that use locally sourced, seasonal, or sustainably grown ingredients — without leaving the platform or doing independent research to verify the claim.

### Make values-aligned choices effortlessly

Users want their health, ethical, and sustainability preferences to be understood and reflected back by the platform recommendations.

### Trust what they're paying a premium for

Users who are willing to pay more for farm-fresh or locally sourced food want a credible signal — a verified badge, a producer name, a distance-to-farm indicator.

### Feel the impact of their choice

Users want acknowledgement that their order made a difference — supporting a local farmer, reducing food miles, choosing seasonal produce.

USERS

# User Personas

HEALTH-CONSCIOUS YOUTH

## Arjun Kapoor

26 · UX Designer · Bengaluru Solo, weekday orderer Fitness-conscious · High frequency · Early adopter

Find locally sourced meals without leaving Zomato to research
Trust the sourcing claim without independently verifying it
Have health preferences remembered and surfaced automatically

PARENTS

## Priya Sharma

38 · Housemaker · Mumbai Family, weekend orderer Parent of two · High trust threshold · Low experimentation

Find restaurants trusted to serve clean, traceable food to her children
Justify premium order pricing with a credible sourcing signal
Expand trusted restaurant shortlist without relying on word of mouth

CORPORATE BUYERS

## Roshni Nair

34 · HR Business Partner · Gurugram Bulk, institutional buyer Approval-gated · Employer-brand driven · B2B context

Source farm-to-table catering that reflects the company's wellness values
Reduce manual effort of vetting sourcing credentials before each bulk order
Generate a reportable sustainability impact summary for HR dashboards

USERS

# Behaviour and Motivation

### Arjun

Googles sourcing credentials before every order — adds 10–15 min friction to a 3-min decision

Willing to pay more for verified fresh and locally grown food

Trusts platform-verified signals over self-declared restaurant claims

Discovers restaurants via food Instagram — orders on Zomato but validates off-platform

### Priya

Rotates through a shortlist of 2–4 trusted restaurants; reluctant to try new ones without a strong recommendation

Reads reviews specifically for mentions of freshness and hygiene — time-consuming and unreliable

Influenced heavily by peer parent recommendations in school and housing society groups

Already pays a premium for organic groceries — the willingness exists, the discovery tool does not

### Roshni

Farm-to-table is an employer-brand and wellness narrative — a strategic statement, not just a meal choice

Calls restaurants directly to vet sourcing credentials before committing to large orders

Manages an approved vendor list — new additions require internal justification and a trial order

Sustainability metrics are increasingly required in HR reporting — impact data has direct internal utility

USERS

# In Their Words

"

I try to eat clean but I spend more time researching where my food comes from than actually ordering it. Zomato just shows me ratings — it doesn't tell me anything about the food itself.

Arjun · 26 · Bengaluru

"

I don't mind spending more if I know it's actually good for my kids. But how do I know? The app tells me nothing about where the food actually comes from.

Priya · 38 · Mumbai

"

When I order for the team, it reflects on the company. I need to show that we care about what we feed our employees — not just that we ordered lunch.

Roshni · 34 · Gurugram

USERS

# Prioritised Persona

PERSONA 1

## Urban Health-Conscious Youth

Arjun Kapoor · 26 · UX Designer · Bengaluru

RATIONALE FOR PRIORITISATION

### Highest frequency, highest data yield

This order frequency means faster feedback loops, richer behavioural data

### Lowest friction to convert

That is a significantly easier conversion than the other two personas

### Strongest AOV growth signal

Building for him directly tests and validates the premium pricing hypothesis

### Largest and most accessible segment

Designing for Arjun captures the widest slice of the target market in the first release

### Early adopter amplifier

He is the acquisition funnel for the other two segments

USERS

# User Stories

### Farm-to-table filter

Given Arjun opens Zomato and wants to order a locally sourced meal, when he applies the farm-to-table filter on the restaurant search screen, then he sees only restaurants with at least one platform-verified sourced dish, updated in under 1 second.

### Sourcing badge on listing card

Given Arjun is browsing the restaurant listing page, when a restaurant has one or more verified farm-to-table dishes on its menu, then a sourcing badge is displayed on its listing card, visible without opening the restaurant.

### Curated farm-fresh collection

Given Arjun opens the Zomato homepage on a weekday, when he has previously ordered from or browsed farm-tagged restaurants, then a personalised "Farm Fresh" collection is surfaced on his homepage as a direct entry point.

### Farmer profile card on dish detail

Given Arjun taps on a farm-tagged dish to view its detail page, when the dish has a linked producer profile, then he sees the farmer's name, farm location, distance from the city, and produce type within the dish detail view.

### Platform-verified sourcing signal

Given Arjun sees a sourcing label on a dish or restaurant, when he wants to assess the credibility of the claim, then the label displays a "Verified by Zomato" indicator distinguishing it from self-declared restaurant descriptions.

### Personalised recommendations

Given Arjun has a history of ordering from and rating farm-tagged dishes, when he opens his Zomato home or discovery feed, then the platform surfaces personalised farm-fresh dish and restaurant recommendations ranked by his past sourcing preferences and ratings.

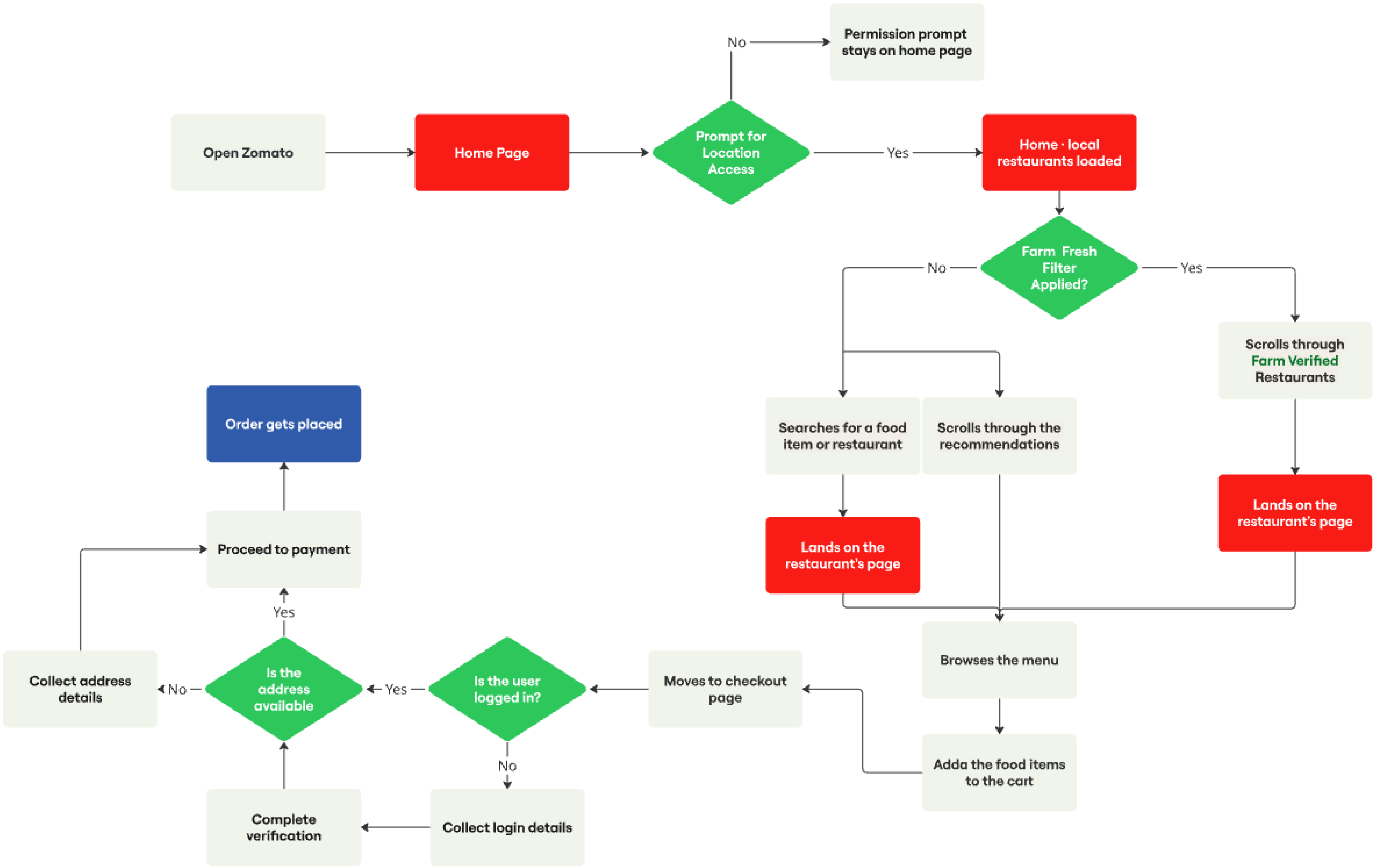
03

# Proposed Solution

Improved user flow · Four solution pillars

# Improved User Flow

ORDER PLACEMENT ON ZOMATO



PROPOSED SOLUTION

# Four Building Blocks

01

### Farm Fresh Discovery

Brings farm-to-table restaurant discovery entirely inside Zomato — replacing Google and Instagram as the user's sourcing research channel.

02

### Verified Sourcing Signal

Replaces unverifiable "farm fresh" marketing copy with a platform-controlled verification layer — named producer, real distance, and a Zomato-audited badge.

03

### Personalisation Flywheel

Makes Zomato progressively smarter about each user's sourcing preferences — so the research effort required reduces with every order, not resets.

04

### Sourcing Trust Infrastructure

The operational and data foundation that makes every consumer-facing feature credible — producer registry, verification workflow, anti-gaming rules, and a two-tier badge system.

04

# Requirements

Functional · Technical · Design · Non-functional

# Discovery and Restaurant Page

## Home and location

If user denies location access — permission prompt remains on home page; no restaurant listings are shown; Farm Fresh rail and filter chip are not rendered.
If user grants location access — home page loads with local restaurants, Farm Fresh rail, and Farm Fresh filter chip all rendered in the same page load.
Two sub-paths available: user searches for a food item or restaurant, or user scrolls through standard recommendations.
In both sub-paths, Farm Verified restaurants display a "Farm Verified" badge on their listing card — a sourcing signal without requiring the filter to be active.

## Restaurant header and menu

Restaurant header displays "Farm Verified ✓" badge alongside existing trust signals (e.g. "Frequently reordered") — badge is tappable and opens the Farm Verified bottom sheet.
Badge shown only when restaurant has at least one dish with verification_status = verified.
Badge removed automatically within 15 minutes if the restaurant's last verified dish lapses or is revoked.
A "Farm Fresh" filter chip is available in the dish filter row — tapping it floats farm-tagged dishes to the top of the menu.
No dish-level Farm Fresh label is displayed on dish cards — sourcing signal is carried at restaurant level only.

## Dish detail and farmer card

Dish detail expands inline — farmer profile card renders below the dish description showing farm name, village and district, computed distance from the user's delivery address, produce types, and a "Verified by Zomato" link.
If dish is linked to multiple producers, all are shown as scrollable cards — one per producer.
Distance computed server-side using the user's saved default delivery address; district-level proximity used as fallback if no saved address.
If producer API is slow, dish detail renders without the farmer card — page does not block.

# Cart, Checkout, and Address

## Cart impact card

System displays a "You're ordering from a Farm Verified restaurant" impact card on the cart page whenever the restaurant holds an active Farm Verified status — regardless of which specific dishes are in the cart.
Secondary line names the producer(s) linked to the restaurant and their distance: "[Producer Name] · X km from your location".
Impact card suppressed if Farm Verified status has lapsed or been revoked — consistent with the 15-minute cache invalidation applied to all other surfaces.
No dish-level label or badge displayed on cart item rows — all rows are visually identical regardless of sourcing status.

## Checkout and login

If logged in, system proceeds directly to address availability check — no login step shown.
Farm Verified impact card remains visible on the checkout screen — impact message persists through the checkout flow.
If not logged in, system redirects to login — collects login details and completes verification (OTP or password).
Cart state must be preserved through the login flow — items added before login must not be lost after authentication.
After successful login, system proceeds to address availability check.

## Address and distance

If address is available, system proceeds to payment — pre-fills saved address on the checkout summary.
Farmer profile card distance recomputes reactively if the user switches delivery address mid-session — distance label updates on next farmer card view.
If recomputed distance exceeds 150 km, the label switches to "Sourced locally in [District Name]" — no specific km figure shown, to prevent a misleading number.
If no address, system prompts the user to enter and save one, then loops back to payment — cart state preserved throughout.
New address is used to recompute farmer card distance for all farm-tagged dishes in the current session.

# Post-Order and Personalisation

### Order and tracking

Order placed successfully — system records which dishes were farm-tagged and which restaurant was Farm Verified at the time of order.

Farm sourcing summary card rendered on the order tracking screen: "You're ordering from a Farm Verified restaurant · [Producer Name] · X km from your location".

### Freshness rating

Post-delivery rating prompt includes an optional "Rate freshness" dimension — framed as "How fresh did the ingredients taste?" with a 1–5 leaf-scale and optional structured tags.

Dimension is suppressed for failed, cancelled, or refunded orders — only shown after a successfully delivered order from a Farm Verified restaurant.

Ratings stored against the restaurant's producer record — contributing to the producer's aggregate freshness score.

Producer freshness score computed using a trimmed mean — top and bottom 10% of ratings removed per rolling 30-day window to reduce outlier influence.

### Personalisation

System computes farm_preference_score nightly: farm-tagged orders (weight 0.5) + browse events (weight 0.3) + freshness ratings (weight 0.2).

Users with score above threshold receive a personalised Farm Fresh rail on the homepage — ranked by individual preference affinity rather than city-level popularity.

Personalised rail copy shifts to "Based on your past orders" — restaurants previously ordered from are deprioritised to surface new discovery options.

Users can toggle farm preference on or off from profile settings — toggling off halts score computation entirely, not just hides the rail (DPDPA 2023 compliant).

REQUIREMENTS

# Technical and Design Requirements

TECHNICAL

API extension with farm_to_table parameter; indexed verification data
Server-driven badge logic; cache invalidation (~15 min)
Batch-processed cached collections; preference-based API exposure
Producer entity model; dish-producer linkage; distance computation
Audit workflow; write-protected verification; expiry + re-audit
Preference scoring model; recommendation integration
Scalable architecture for large datasets

DESIGN

Visible filter chip with intuitive UI; graceful empty states
Prominent badge; consistent visual identity
Homepage carousel; optimised info density
Dish-level labels; farmer profile cards
Verified badge with explainer; credibility hierarchy
Context-aware UI; user toggle control
Accessible UI (WCAG compliant)

REQUIREMENTS

# Non-functional Requirements

### Scalability

Schema supports 50K producers and 500K tagged dishes without architectural changes in Phase 1–3

### Reliability

Sourcing data service target uptime 99.9%; all surfaces degrade gracefully on failure

### Privacy

DPDPA 2023 compliant; preference toggle = full data processing opt-out, not a UI preference only

### Accessibility

WCAG 2.1 AA — all Farm Fresh UI elements include aria-labels; colour never the sole differentiator. iOS VoiceOver and Android TalkBack compatibility required for the bottom sheet and all new interactive components

### Security

verification_status write-protected; farm location data returned at district level only to consumers

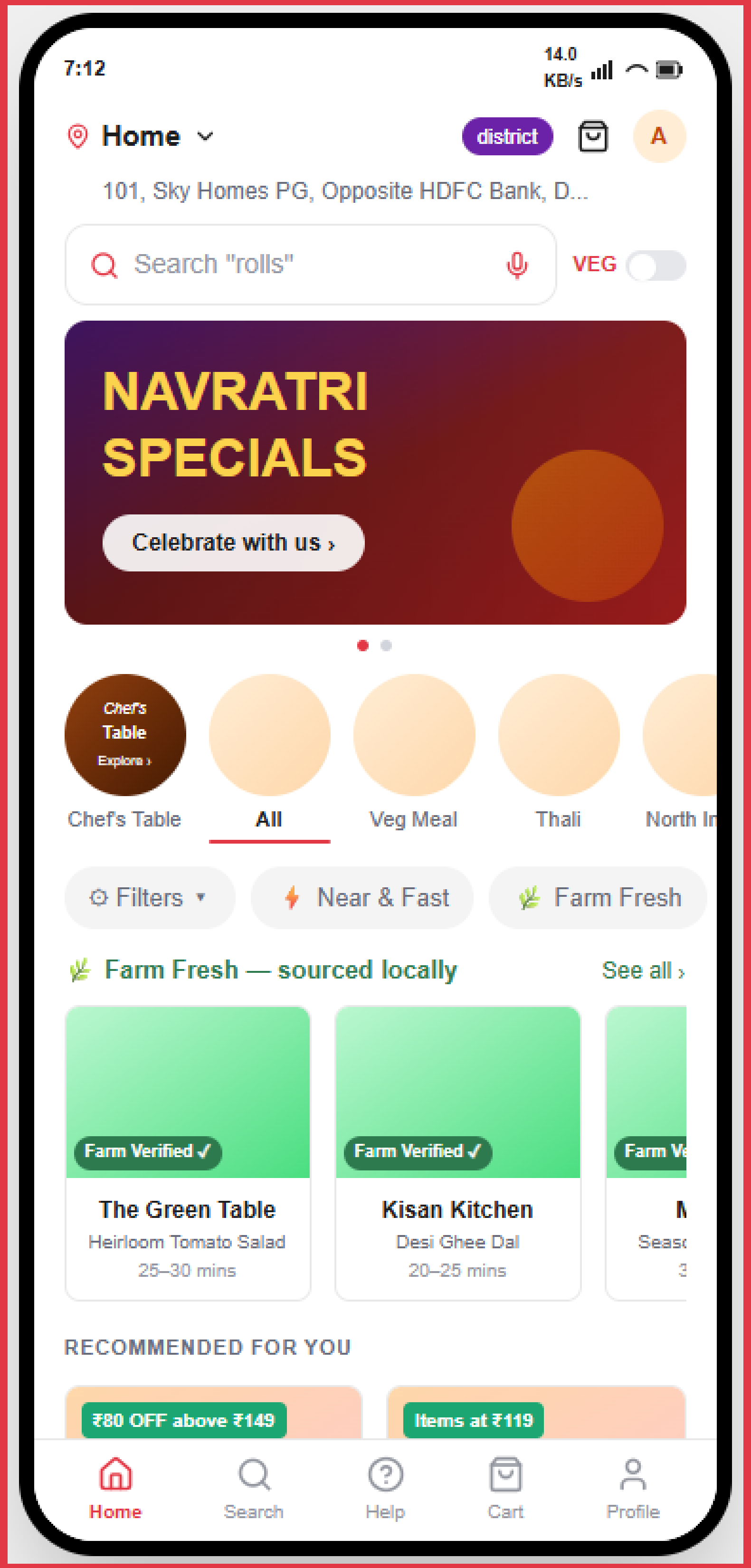
05

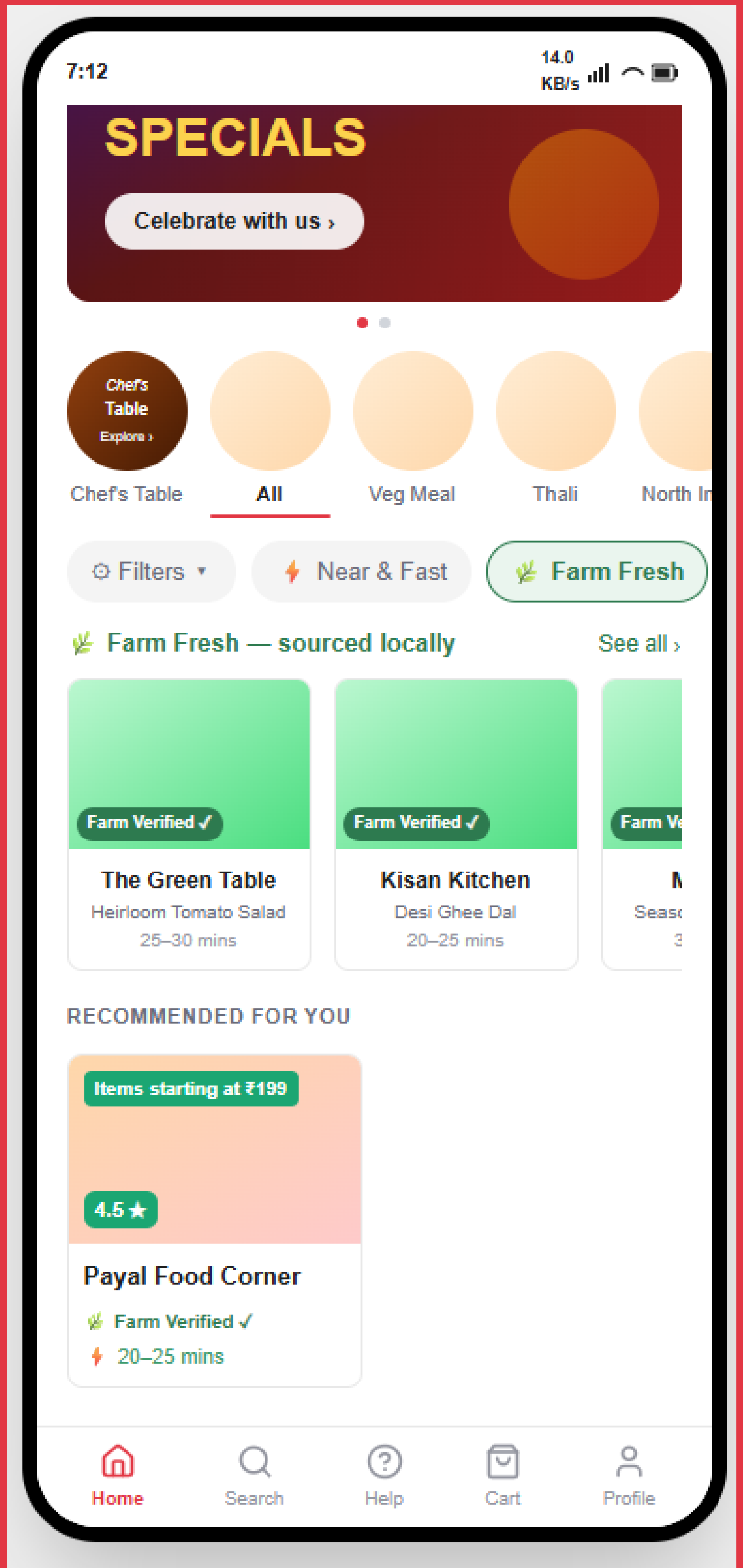
# Mockups

Discovery · Restaurant · Cart · Order tracking

# Home and Discovery

FARM FRESH FILTER CHIP · FARM FRESH RAIL




## Farm Fresh rail

"Farm Fresh — sourced locally" rail renders on the same page load as local restaurants, with Farm Verified badges on each card.

## Filter chip

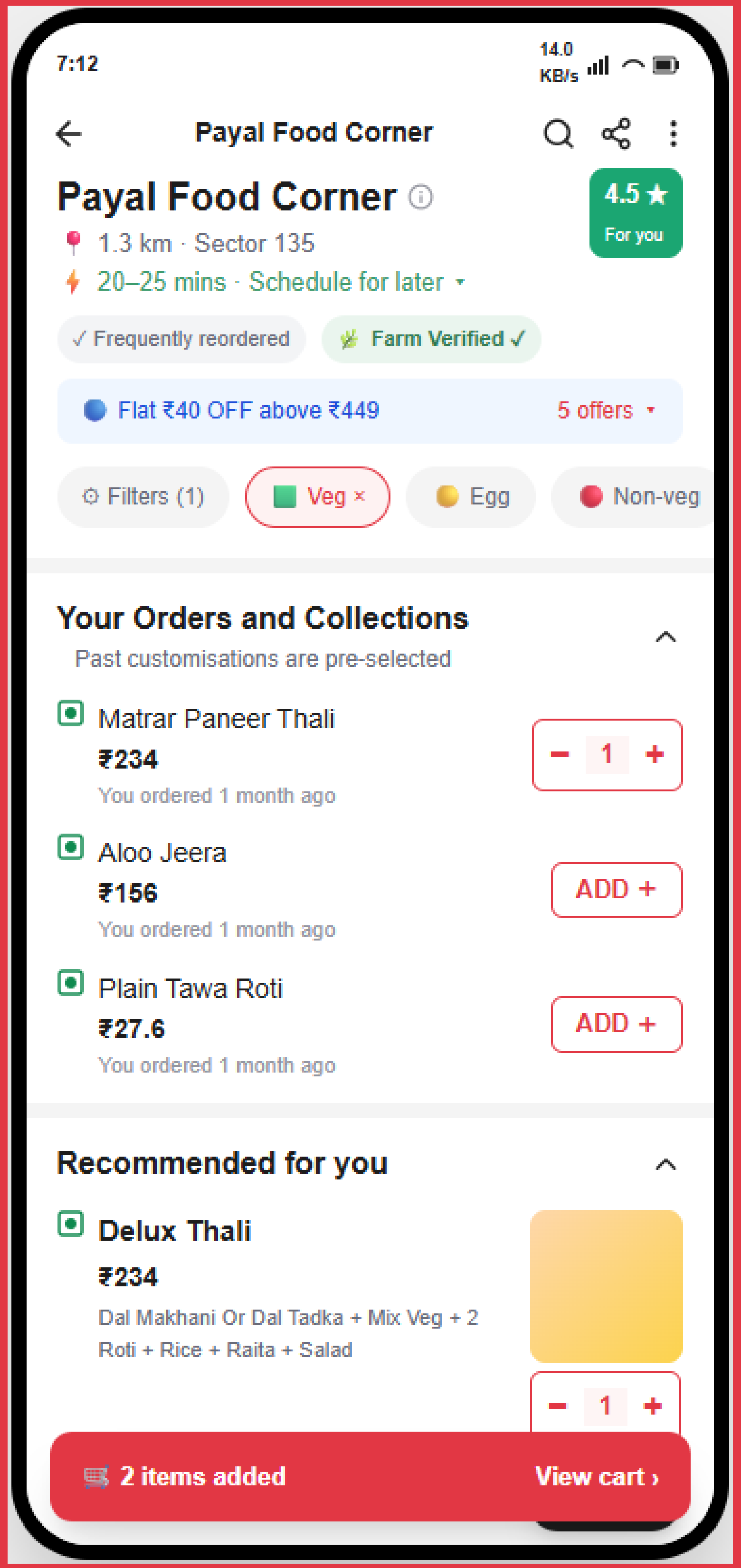
Farm Fresh sits in the existing filter row beside Near & Fast — active state floats verified restaurants into the recommendations feed.

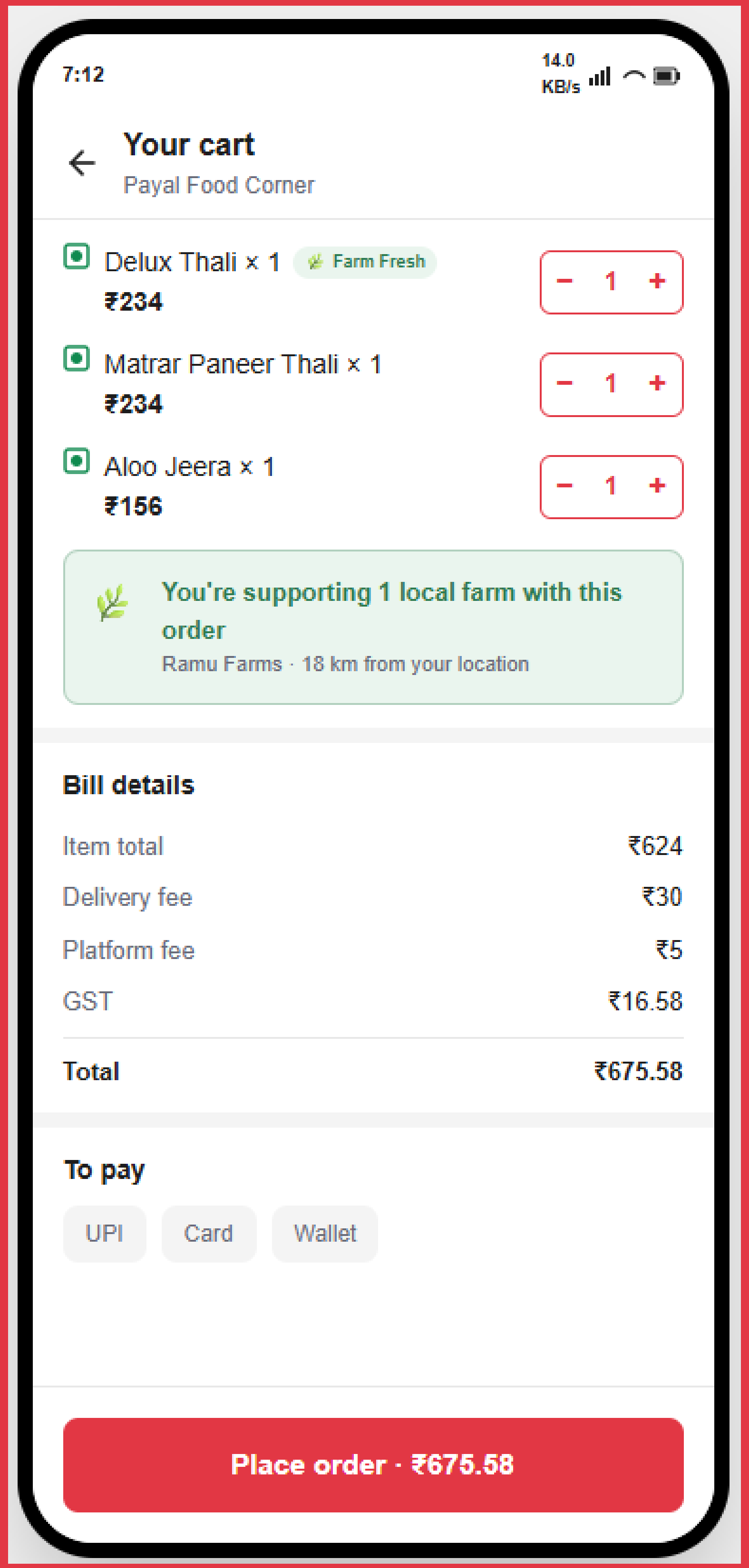
## Badge in the feed

Recommended-for-you cards carry the badge inline, so the sourcing signal is visible without the filter being active.

# Restaurant Page and Cart

HEADER BADGE · IMPACT CARD




## Header badge

"Farm Verified ✓" sits alongside existing trust signals such as "Frequently reordered", and is tappable to open the verification bottom sheet.

## Impact card

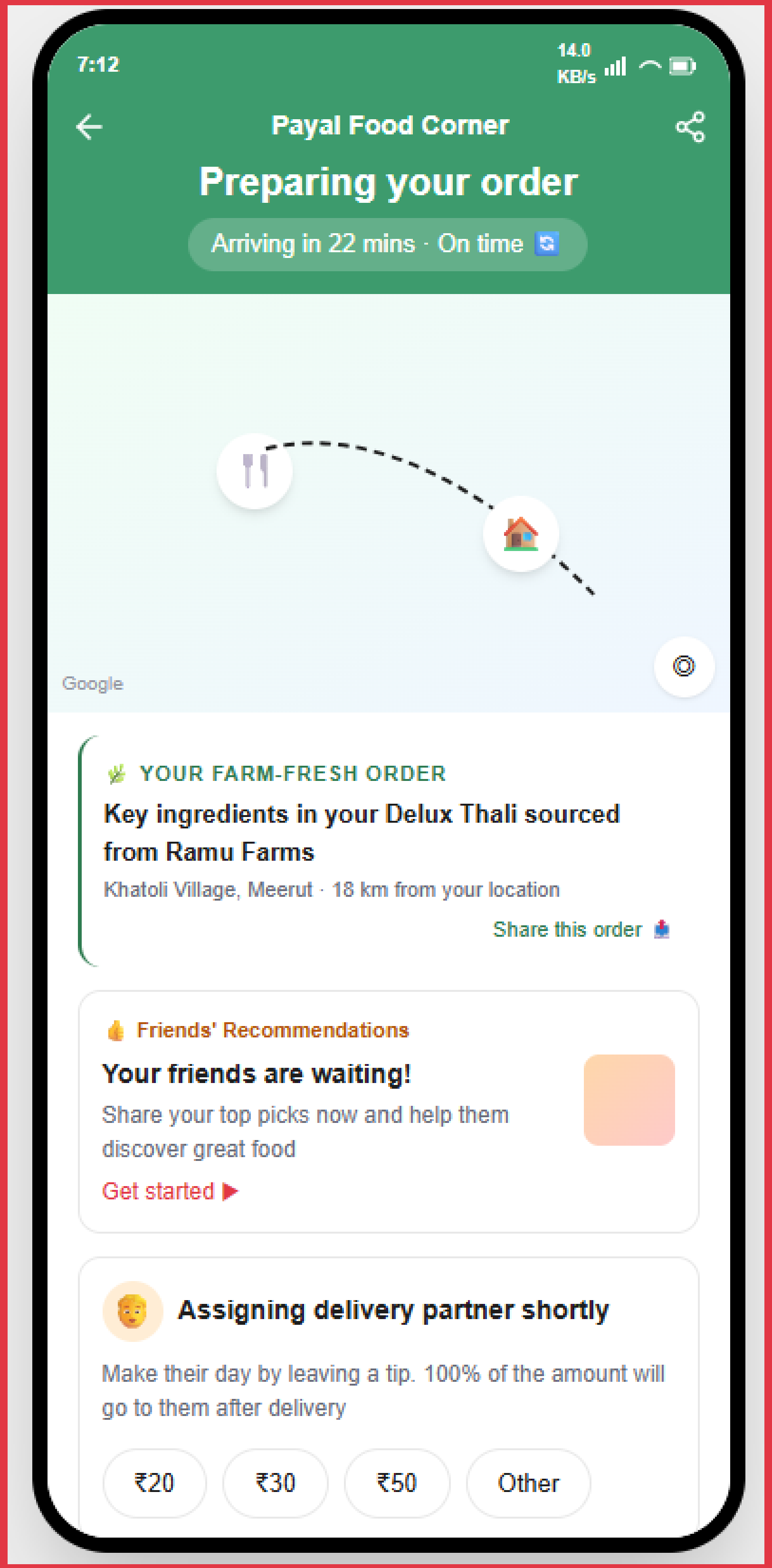
"You're supporting 1 local farm with this order" names the producer and the distance — Ramu Farms · 18 km from your location.

## Unchanged cart rows

Item rows stay visually identical regardless of sourcing status; the signal is carried once, at restaurant level.

# Order Tracking

FARM SOURCING SUMMARY CARD




## Sourcing summary

"Key ingredients in your Delux Thali sourced from Ramu Farms" — Khatoli Village, Meerut · 18 km from your location, with a share action.

## Freshness rating

After a successful delivery, the rating prompt adds "How fresh did the ingredients taste?" on a 1–5 leaf scale, feeding the producer's freshness score.

FUNCTIONAL PROTOTYPE

**Farm-to-Fresh by Zomato ↗**

06

# Verification, Edge Cases, Metrics

SOP for Farm-Fresh Verified status · Edge cases · Success metrics

SOP · TIER 1 — DECLARATION REQUIREMENTS

# What the Restaurant Must Declare

| | |
|---|---|
| **Producer identity** | Full legal name and registration number of the producer or FPO. Must be a registered entity — FPO, Kisan Credit Card holder, or APMC-registered trader. Unregistered intermediaries not accepted. |
| **Ingredient scope** | Specific ingredient(s) declared, not the whole dish. Declared ingredient must appear in the dish name or contribute more than 30% of the dish's raw ingredient weight. Garnishes, condiments, and finishing herbs explicitly excluded. |
| **Geography** | Farm must be within 150 km straight-line distance of the restaurant's registered address. Supply chain must be direct — maximum one intermediary between farm and restaurant. |
| **Supply frequency** | Minimum weekly or more frequent supply. Seasonal or one-time sourcing does not qualify. Three consecutive purchase invoices from the declared producer within the last 90 days required. |
| **Produce eligibility** | Eligible: fresh vegetables, fruits, dairy, pulses, grains, herbs, eggs. Processed or packaged goods explicitly excluded — no packaged spice mixes, bottled sauces, or manufactured ingredients. |

SOP · TIER 2 — AUDIT CHECKS

# What Zomato Verifies

### Document verification

Producer GSTIN must be live on the GST portal

Invoice amounts must appear in the restaurant's own GST input credit filings for that period

Producer's GSTIN must appear directly on restaurant purchase invoices — not an intermediary's

### Physical verification

Timestamped photo or video of fresh produce received from the declared producer — showing the delivery challan or producer packaging label alongside the produce

### Renewal cadence

Invoices submitted on a rolling 90-day basis throughout a 6-month badge cycle — at months 1, 3, and 5

Badge displays the "last verified" date on the consumer-facing verification bottom sheet

EDGE CASES · CONSUMER-FACING

# Where Trust Can Break

01 A user orders a farm-tagged dish but the restaurant substitutes the sourced ingredient on a specific day due to stock shortage — the consumer receives a non-farm-sourced version of a dish they believed was farm-sourced, with no disclosure.

02 A user gives a low freshness rating not because the sourcing was compromised but because the dish was prepared poorly — the rating unfairly penalises the producer's freshness score.

03 The farmer profile card shows a distance of "18 km from your location" but the user changes their delivery address mid-session to a different city — the distance becomes stale and misleading.

SUCCESS METRICS

# How We Measure It

## DEMAND SIDE

No. of orders containing at least one Farm-Verified dish
Cart-to-order conversion rate on farm-tagged carts
Farm Fresh filter usage rate
AOV for orders with ≥ 1 Farm-Verified dish

## SUPPLY SIDE

Restaurant sourcing declaration rate
Verification approval rate
Verified dish count per restaurant